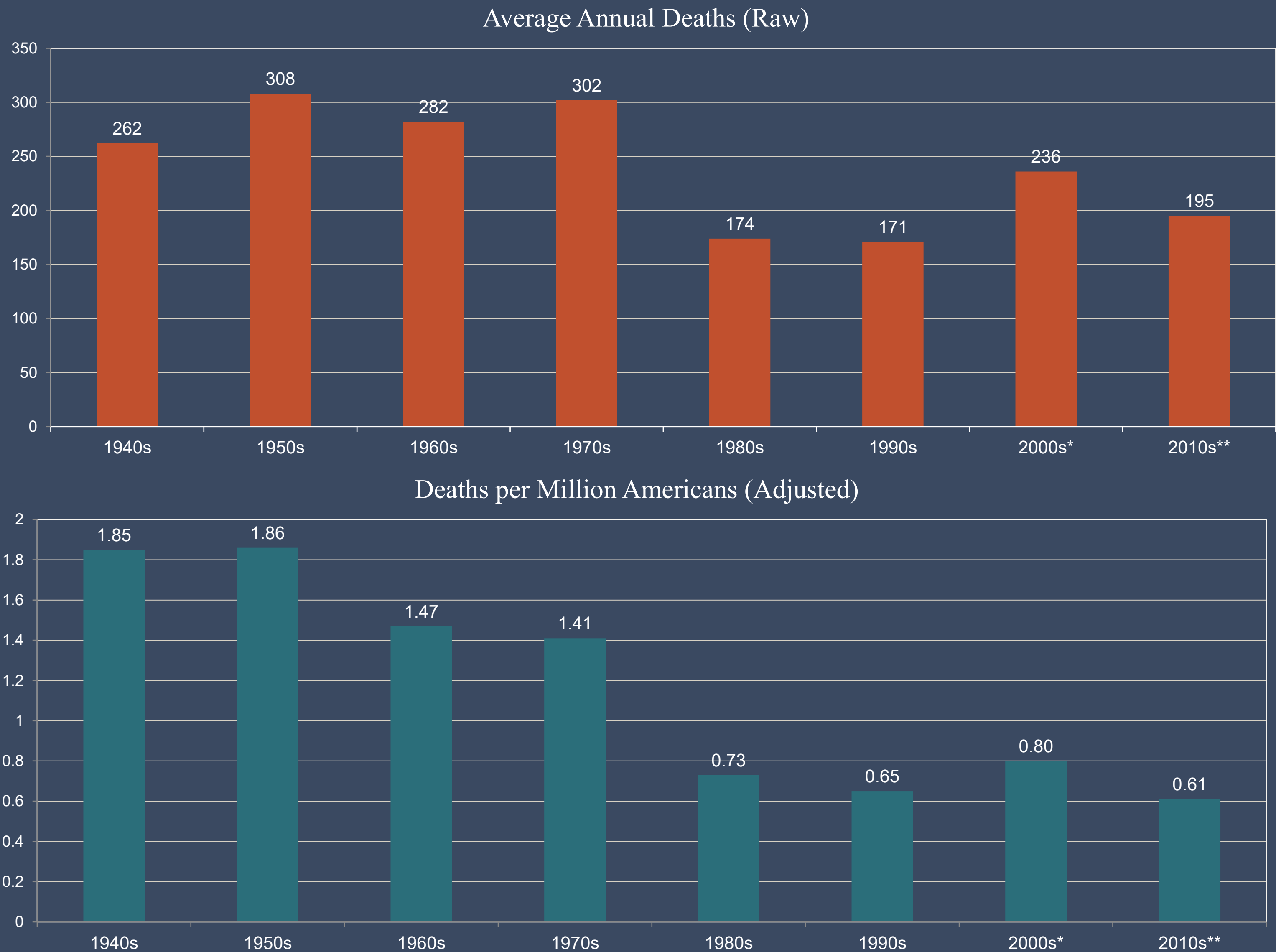


Safer From Storms, Closer To Danger

Eighty years of U.S. weather data show a country that has gotten dramatically better at surviving tornadoes, floods, and hurricanes, even as more Americans move directly into the riskiest places to live.

Why the Raw Number Are Misleading

Total storm deaths look choppy and stubborn. Divide by the population exposed, and a much clearer story appears.



*2000s spiked by Hurricane Katrina (2005) **2010s spiked by the 2011 tornado outbreak - single catastrophic years, not a trend reversal.
Source: NWS/NOAA, 80-Year Severe Weather Fatality Statistics.

Americans Are Moving Toward the Risk, Not Away From It

84%	64%
Coastal county population growth, 1960-2008	Inland county population growth, same period

Important Caveat

Not all “weather deaths” are counted the same way. The figures above come from direct fatality reports. But separate research (Burke et al., 2025, NBER Working Paper #34313) estimates that ambient temperature is responsible for 5-12% of all deaths in the U.S. and Europe, using statistical attribution methods, not direct classification

What Economics Adds

The falling death rate isn’t about avoidance, instead it’s about adaptation: better warnings, stronger codes, faster evacuations, technology that lowers the cost of living somewhere risky.

People aren’t ignoring risk, they’re pricing it against everything else they value. These are jobs, weather, family, retirement and deciding the tradeoff is worth it compared to the danger.

But Wait

None of this proves migration into risk zones is costless. A death rate falling even as exposure rises is consistent with real adaptation, but it’s also consistent with disasters getting more expensive rather than more deadly. The burden then shifting from lives lost to property destroyed and rebuilt. Falling death tolls are not the same as falling total cost.